

She asked us all to introduce ourselves and tell the rest of the class what we did for a living.

“Hi,” I said. “I’m Andrea Dickson, and I’m a writer—”

“Stop right there,” intoned our instructor. “Why are you asking a question?”

“Huh?”

“When you told us your name. You said, ‘My name is Andrea Dickson? and I’m a writer . . .’”

“That’s just basic inflection. People talk that way when we have more to say.”

Think about it. When you’re telling a story, your voice will tilt upward at the end of a phrase, indicating that the story is continuing.

This is fine for much of our normal conversation. But as our instructor pointed out, we use upward inflection only when talking about things that aren’t as important as the climax of the story. When I introduce myself as “Andrea Dickson?” I am putting less emphasis on my name than I should.

When you are introducing yourself to another person, one on one, you will say your name with downward inflection, like a statement. “I’m Andrea. Good to meet you.” But when you introduce yourself in front of an audience, you start with your name and move on to something else.

In those contexts, it’s important to make sure that you introduce yourself as though your name is a statement. Your first name should inflect upward, and your last name should inflect downward. So it should sound more like “My name is Andrea? Dickson.” Follow with a slight pause, then continue with the rest of your introduction. Actually, don’t use my name, unless you want to be mobbed by thousands of screaming fans.

Try it by yourself a few dozen times, and then try it out next time you have to give a talk or introduce yourself to a group. You’ll be pleasantly surprised at what a difference it makes in the overall tone of your introduction. — **Andrea Karim (formerly Dickson)**

13 Ways to Be Nice That Will Cost You Nothing



It’s not expensive to be nice—in fact, it often costs nothing. Here are 13 easy ways to be nice that will cost you nothing.